ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

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Sleep, Fitness and Posture: The Physical Habits Behind Good Grades

Small daily routines that protect memory, mood and your back

HEALTH & WELLBEING

Health & Wellbeing

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Sleep and movement are not luxuries to be traded for study hours - they are part of how learning is consolidated. This pack covers sleep hygiene, a no-equipment exercise routine, posture for long study sessions and recovering after late nights.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Explain the role of sleep in memory and mood.
- Apply sleep-hygiene practices in a hostel environment.
- Follow a simple weekly exercise routine without equipment.
- Correct posture during long study sessions and screen use.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Sleep is study time

Memory consolidation happens during sleep, so cutting sleep reduces what you keep.

- Adults need roughly seven to nine hours, with consistent timing.
- Sleep supports memory consolidation, emotional regulation and immune function.
- Caffeine after mid-afternoon and late-night screens delay sleep onset.
- All-nighters produce short-term recall but impair understanding and accuracy.
- A consistent wind-down routine signals the body to sleep.
- If you must sleep late, keep the wake time stable rather than shifting both.

> **After a late night**
> Prioritise a short recovery nap, daylight, water and a normal bedtime the next day. Sleeping all day resets your rhythm in the wrong direction.

Movement without a gym

Consistency matters more than intensity.

- Aim for 150 minutes of moderate activity per week, spread across days.
- Bodyweight basics: squats, push-ups (wall or floor), lunges, planks, glute bridges.
- Walking briskly to lectures counts as activity.
- Stretch hip flexors, hamstrings and chest after long sitting.
- Warm up for five minutes and progress gradually.
- Stop and seek advice if you feel chest pain, dizziness or joint injury.

Posture and screen habits

Long hours hunched over a phone affect neck, shoulders and concentration.

- Raise your screen to eye level and keep feet flat on the floor.
- Keep the lower back supported and elbows near 90 degrees.
- Follow the 20-20-20 rule: every 20 minutes, look 20 feet away for 20 seconds.
- Stand and move for two minutes every 45 to 60 minutes.
- Carry bags evenly or use a backpack with two straps.
- Do not study lying flat with a laptop on your chest.

Sleep is where learning is consolidated

Sleep is not lost time from study; it is part of studying. Memory consolidation happens during sleep, and sleep deprivation impairs attention, working memory and emotional regulation before it impairs anything you would notice subjectively. People who are sleep-deprived are reliably worse at judging how impaired they are.

The two practical levers are regularity and light. A consistent wake time stabilises the body clock more effectively than a consistent bedtime. Morning daylight and dim evening light reinforce the same rhythm; bright screens late at night do the opposite.

Caffeine has a half-life of about five hours, which means a 4 p.m. coffee still has a quarter of its effect at midnight. Alcohol helps people fall asleep and then fragments sleep in the second half of the night.

Movement you will actually do

The best exercise is the one you continue. For students, that usually means something free, nearby and social: walking, running, football, skipping, bodyweight circuits, or a gym shared with friends. Twenty to thirty minutes most days is enough to produce real benefits for mood, sleep and concentration.

The World Health Organization recommends at least 150 minutes of moderate activity per week plus muscle-strengthening twice weekly. That is twenty-two minutes a day, or three longer sessions. It does not require equipment or a membership.

Warm up before and cool down after. Progress gradually - increases of about ten per cent per week - and take rest days. Most student injuries come from doing too much suddenly, often in the first week of a new routine.

> **Movement breaks beat caffeine**
> Five minutes of walking and stretching restores concentration more reliably than another cup of coffee, and it does not cost sleep later.

Posture, screens and back pain

There is no single perfect posture; the problem is staying in one position for hours. Change position regularly, stand up every thirty to forty-five minutes, and adjust the screen so the top is at eye level and the keyboard so the elbows are near ninety degrees.

When studying on a bed or floor for long periods, support the lower back and keep the neck neutral rather than flexed forward. A rolled cloth or a small cushion helps. Reading a phone while lying on your side with the neck bent is a common cause of persistent neck pain.

Carrying a heavy bag on one shoulder produces asymmetrical loading. Use both straps, reduce the load, and alternate sides if you must carry a single bag. Persistent pain, numbness or weakness needs assessment rather than a posture video.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Fixing a broken sleep schedule

You sleep at 2 a.m., wake at 10, and feel unrefreshed.

1. Set a fixed wake time and keep it for two weeks, including weekends.
2. Get outside within an hour of waking for daylight exposure.
3. Move the bedtime earlier by 15 minutes every three days.
4. Stop caffeine after midday.
5. Dim screens for the last hour and keep the phone out of the bed.
6. Do not nap longer than twenty minutes, and not after 4 p.m.

> **What to carry forward**
> Fix the wake time first. The bedtime follows.

2. A fifteen-minute daily routine

You have no gym access and limited time.

1. Five minutes: brisk walking or skipping to warm up.
2. Five minutes: bodyweight circuit - squats, press-ups, lunges, plank.
3. Three minutes: repeat the circuit once at lower intensity.
4. Two minutes: stretch the back, hips and calves.
5. Do it at the same time most days.
6. Increase repetitions by about ten per cent each week.

> **What to carry forward**
> Consistency beats intensity. Fifteen minutes daily outperforms one heroic session a month.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Explain how sleep deprivation affects academic performance.

15 marks

1. Impaired attention and working memory.
2. Reduced consolidation of learned material.
3. Poor emotional regulation and motivation.
4. Impaired self-assessment of performance.

Q2. What are the recommended physical activity levels for adults, and how can a student meet them?

10 marks

1. 150 minutes of moderate activity weekly.
2. Muscle strengthening twice weekly.
3. Ways to meet them: walking, sport, bodyweight circuits.
4. Gradual progression and rest days.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Circadian rhythm. The roughly 24-hour internal cycle regulating sleep and alertness.

Sleep hygiene. Habits and conditions that support regular, sufficient sleep.

Consolidation. The stabilising of memory during sleep.

Half-life. The time taken for half of a substance to be cleared from the body.

Moderate activity. Exercise that raises breathing rate while still allowing speech.

Progressive overload. Gradually increasing training demand to build capacity.

Ergonomics. Arranging work conditions to fit the body and reduce strain.

Neutral spine. A spinal alignment that maintains its natural curves.

RPE. Rate of perceived exertion, a simple way to gauge exercise intensity.

Recovery. Rest and adaptation after physical or mental demand.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Sleep

Regularity.

- Set a fixed wake time.
- Get daylight within an hour of waking.
- Record sleep hours.

Week 2 - Caffeine and screens

Triggers.

- No caffeine after midday.
- Screens off one hour before bed.
- Phone out of the bed.

Week 3 - Move

Habit.

- Do fifteen minutes daily.
- Walk instead of short transport trips.
- Add two strengthening sessions.

Week 4 - Posture

Study set-up.

- Adjust screen and keyboard height.
- Stand every 40 minutes.
- Use both bag straps.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- A sleep science guide for students.
- WHO physical activity recommendations.
- An ergonomics guide for laptop study setups.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Why does sleep matter for academic performance?

Answer: Sleep consolidates memory, restores attention and regulates mood, all of which directly affect learning and exam performance.

2. What is the 20-20-20 rule?

Answer: Every 20 minutes, look at something about 20 feet away for 20 seconds to reduce eye strain.

3. List four bodyweight exercises that need no equipment.

Answer: Squats, push-ups, lunges and planks. Glute bridges and step-ups also qualify.

4. Why is a consistent wake time important?

Answer: It anchors the body clock, making sleep onset and waking more predictable.

5. Give two posture corrections for laptop study.

Answer: Raise the screen to eye level and keep feet flat with the lower back supported.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Set a consistent sleep and wake time for two weeks.
- [ ] Create a 20-minute wind-down routine without screens.
- [ ] Plan three 30-minute activity sessions for the week.
- [ ] Learn a five-minute stretching routine.
- [ ] Adjust your study desk to eye-level screen height.
- [ ] Apply the 20-20-20 rule during one study session.
- [ ] Track sleep and energy for a week and compare.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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